

POUCHED MAMMALS

These mammals bear live young that are born in a very immature state, and typically complete their growth in the mother's abdominal pouch.

Marsupials inhabit a vast array of habitats from desert and dry scrub to tropical rainforest. Most of them are either terrestrial or arboreal, but several glide, one is aquatic, and there are two marsupial moles that live underground. The diets of marsupials are equally wide-ranging: among the different species are carnivores, insectivores, herbivores, and omnivores. There are even marsupials that feed on nectar and pollen. Marsupials also differ markedly in size, from the tiny planigales, which are among the smallest mammals in the world, weighing less than 4.5 g (about 1/3 oz), to the red kangaroo, males of which can weigh over 90 kg (200 lb).

EARLY DEVELOPMENT

Young marsupials are born blind and furless. They make their way through the mother's fur and latch on to a nipple and suckle. In around half of marsupial species, the nipples are located

in a protective pouch. Some marsupials have only one offspring at a time, but others may have up to a dozen or more. The phase during which young are in the pouch is equivalent to the gestation period of placental mammals.

Kangaroos and some other marsupials are able to stop the development of an embryo before it implants in the uterus if they already have an infant occupying the pouch. The pregnancy continues when the pouch is vacated.

THE SEVEN ORDERS

Pouched mammals, known as marsupials, are now divided into seven major groups. These are: the American opossums, order Didelphimorphia; the shrew opossums, order Paucituberculata; monito del monte, the sole member of the order Microbiotheria; the Australasian carnivorous marsupials, order Dasyuromorphia; bandicoots, order Peramelemorphia; the marsupial moles, order Notoryctemorphia; and the Australasian marsupials of Diprotodontia, the largest order of pouched mammals, which includes the koala, wombats, possums, wallabies, and kangaroos.

PHYLUM	CHORDATA
CLASS	MAMMALIA
ORDERS	7
FAMILIES	18
SPECIES	OVER 350

DEBATE

NOT SO PRIMITIVE?

Pouched mammals were once considered primitive because their young are born at an early stage without prolonged nourishment by a placenta inside the mother. Scientists now know that this reproductive strategy is an adaptation to their environment and that pouched mammals are just as advanced as placental mammals. Kangaroos can support two dependent juveniles of different ages, and a fertile egg that can develop almost immediately should anything happen to the other two. This strategy means pouched mammals recover quickly when harsh environmental conditions abate.

SHREW OPOSSUMS

Fewer incisor teeth distinguish the members of the family Caenolestidae from other American marsupials. All eight species occur in the Andes in western S. America.



DUSKY SHREW OPOSSUM
Caenolestes fuliginosus

Living at high altitudes in Colombia, Ecuador, and Venezuela, this shrew opossum uses its large lower incisors to kill prey.

9–14 cm
3½–5½ in

MONITO DEL MONTE

The sole member of the family Microbiotheriidae, the monito del monte is well adapted to the cold. It uses both daily torpor and seasonal hibernation to conserve energy when temperatures are low or food is in short supply.



MONITO DEL MONTE
Dromiciops gliroides

Inhabiting cool bamboo forest and temperate rainforest in Chile and Argentina, this species has dense fur to limit heat loss.

8–13 cm
3¼–5 in

MARSUPIAL MOLES

Two species of Australian marsupial moles form the family Notoryctidae. Their short limbs, large claws, and horned nose-shield help them to burrow. They lack external ears and have non-functional eyes.



11–14 cm
4½–5½ in

SOUTHERN MARSUPIAL MOLE
Notoryctes typhlops

This marsupial mole is specialized for burrowing in the sandy desert and spinifex grassland of C. Australia.

OPOSSUMS

The New World opossums of the family Didelphidae have a pointed muzzle with sensitive whiskers, and naked ears. Many species have a grasping, prehensile tail that helps when climbing. Some opossums lack pouches.



VIRGINIA OPOSSUM
Didelphis virginiana

The largest American marsupial, this species lives in grasslands and temperate and tropical forests in the USA, Mexico, and C. America.

37–50 cm
14½–20 in



BROWN-EARED WOOLLY OPOSSUM
Caluromys lanatus

Also known as the western woolly opossum, this arboreal, solitary opossum inhabits moist forests in western and central S. America.

20–32 cm
8–12½ in



BARE-TAILED WOOLLY OPOSSUM
Caluromys philander

This woolly opossum's long, prehensile tail helps it move through the canopy of moist rainforests across eastern and central S. America.

16–28 cm
6½–11 in